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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Wanted: Running mate for governor

Pritzker will push for a third term. Who will be his No. 2?

By Olivia Olander and Rick Pearson
Chicago Tribune

Gov. JB Pritzker is hiring. Job duties include cutting ribbons and influencing state policy. Opportunities for promotion? Pending the outcome of the 2028 presidential race.

As the governor begins campaigning for his third term, the question of who will be the chief executive’s second-in-command is the biggest in Illinois’ political world this summer.

The job will become vacant with the state’s two-term lieutenant governor, Juliana Stratton, running to succeed retiring U.S. Sen. Dick Durbin.

“They’ve got to be somebody who can do the job — if something happens and they had to take over,” Pritzker said, describing his ideal running mate to reporters Thursday in Chicago. “And I think just as importantly, somebody who really has a heart for the people of the state of Illinois. That’s not in everybody, right? But you got to have somebody who actually cares about all parts of the state.”

Whoever takes on the job will not only need to jibe with the governor in the traditional duties of the office, but also prepare to take on a greater role than most lieutenant governors have historically due to Pritzker’s presidential interests.

Should Pritzker win the presidency, the lieutenant governor would take over the final two years of the governor’s four-year term and be expected to pursue the work Pritzker has initiated. And although a lieutenant governor — a position that’s derisively been called “lite gov” because the office’s powers are so minuscule — has no more responsibility running state government when the governor is out of state, the next such officeholder may be expected to step up more

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Landon Mosley, left, and Jess Saltz, right, embrace a marcher wearing a “Free Dad Hugs” shirt during the 54th annual Chicago Pride Parade on Sunday in Lakeview. Thousands filled the sidewalks and side streets of the Northalsted neighborhood for the event. **Story on Page 3**

A more defensive Pride Month

Activists say celebrations are increasingly vital as federal government, Indiana and other conservative states rescind LGBTQ+ protections

By Angie Leventis Lourgos
Chicago Tribune

Christopher Colwell of Valparaiso, Indiana, teared up a bit as his grandmother sang with her church choir during Northwest Indiana Pridefest early this month, calling the moment a haven of acceptance in a state and nation that have become increasingly hostile to queer men like him.

The grandson and grandma briefly embraced after her performance on a stage adorned with rainbow-colored balloons and a giant pride flag.

“I can’t stand the current climate in this state. It don’t represent its people anymore,” said Colwell, 25, at the June 8 event at Riverview Park in Lake Station. “I have a really poor outlook on the country as a whole.”

While Pride Month events in the past were largely celebrations of the rights the LGBTQ+ community has secured — as well



Christopher Colwell, left, becomes emotional and hugs his grandparents Maggie Reister and Tom Walters after being moved by an interfaith service June 8 during Northwest Indiana Pridefest in Lake Station, Ind. All three live in Valparaiso, Ind. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE PHOTOS**

as promotions for greater representation and acceptance — many activists say the focus this year has been on girding protections and freedoms that are being actively

rolled back on the federal level as well as in many Republican-led states such as Indiana.

“For the LGBTQ community, there’s a lot of anxiety about

the rights that we have and are they going to stick around much longer?” said the Rev. Leah Peksenak, president of NWI Pridefest Inc. and pastor of two northwest Indiana churches. “It’s less about let’s celebrate what we have and try to push for more. Now it’s like, we might have to really dig in our heels and refuse to relinquish what we’ve already won. Because we’re not going backward.”

This is in stark contrast to more liberal states such as Illinois, which have been strengthening LGBTQ+ rights and protections in the face of a national movement to rescind many of them.

Illinois Attorney General Kwame Raoul this month filed an amicus brief, along with 20 other states, defending a Michigan law that bars health officials from practicing so-called conversion therapy on LGBTQ+ children.

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Mistake by ICE puts woman’s husband in jail

After more than 3 weeks and \$12,000 spent, couple reunited

By Sophie Levenson
Chicago Tribune

In the early morning light outside O’Hare International Airport, Cynthia Myers was dressed like a bride.

Her long white dress seemed curiously out of place Friday on the curb outside Terminal 3, but Myers didn’t seem to notice; the man in the slightly loose black suit had her full attention.

After three weeks in a Louisiana jail — because of an apparent error by U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement — Cheikh Fall had finally come home to his wife. On his overnight flights from Monroe, Louisiana, to Dallas and then Indianapolis, he wore the same suit he’d had on when immigration authorities wrongfully arrested him outside his asylum hearing in the Chicago Immigration Court on June 4.

It took more than \$12,000 and 23 sleepless nights, but Myers got her husband back. She knew he would be wearing the suit so she dressed up like his newlywed bride to celebrate the reunion she gleefully dubbed their “remarriage.”

Myers couldn’t stop laughing.



Cynthia Myers and her husband, Cheikh Fall, celebrate as they are reunited outside O’Hare International Airport in Chicago on Friday. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

“I’m so happy,” she said, over and over again.

For three weeks, she hadn’t been. She and her children have become one of the thousands of families in the United States affected by the Trump administration’s intensi-

fied deportation efforts.

Last week, ICE was holding close to 59,000 detainees nationwide, CBS reported, almost half of them with clean criminal records — stretching its system to 140% of capacity.

The day of Fall’s routine asylum hearing, Myers was nervous. She said she was well aware of recent ICE activity and asked her husband if he thought it was the

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Senate Democrats drag out Trump bill

Measure would add \$3.3 trillion to debt, CBO analysis finds

By Lisa Mascaro, Kevin Freking and Joey Cappelletti
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — Hours before a tumultuous near-midnight vote on President Donald Trump’s package of tax breaks, spending cuts and increased deportation money, a Republican senator stood on the chamber floor and implored the plan’s critics: “Read the bill.”

After the dramatic 51-49 roll call late Saturday, Senate Democrats did just that.

Unable to stop the march toward passage of the 940-page bill by Trump’s Fourth of July deadline, the minority party in Congress is using the tools at its disposal to delay and drag out the process.

By Sunday afternoon, about

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